Three decades ago, India embarked on much needed reforms and opened up its economy. The benefits of doing so are undisputed. However, in the name of efficiency and modernity, easy options were taken at the expense of our small and medium enterprises (SMEs). Instead of building effective domestic supply chains, we opted for integration and value addition that were more profitable and less painstaking. Infrastructure projects were given out to others without any effort to absorb learnings for our own industry. The pursuit of short-term gains made us lose ambition and, with that, a sense of strategy. As a result, economic growth did not witness the commensurate scaling up of skills, strengths and capacities.

In the last decade, we have awoken to the realization that mantras about globalization, if mindlessly applied, can cause real damage. Not just that, if economic choices are divorced from a strategic context, it could lead the country down a very dangerous path. The real debate is not whether we should be an open or a protected economy. It is whether we are an employment-centric and capability-driven one or just a profit-obsessed society content to be a market. Along with vulnerabilities, a dependent mindset has also been rationalized, which masquerades as globalized thinking. India’s destiny is bigger than to be just a part of the future of others. Real growth is not only about GDP increase; it is equally about infrastructure, supply chains, skills, finance and socio-economic progress. When we sacrifice the latter for the former, our long-term prospects are imperilled. We could slide into strategic lock-ins without even being aware. Foreign policy is surely an instrument to advance our strategic course; it is equally an insurance that our big picture is the right one.

In an era of more interdependence and interpenetration, it is also expected that all nations will seek to expand their zones of deep influence beyond their national boundaries. In the past, trade, finance, military activities and migration were some of the means to do so. Nowadays, the role of connectivity and socio-economic collaboration has become more salient. This is an important realization for a nation like India, whose reach was constrained by Partition. As we grow in different dimensions, strategic sense dictates that our prosperity serves as a larger incentive for the entire region. Realizing this, the Modi government has significantly expanded connectivity and collaborative initiatives with neighbours. Its results are evident in new road and rail connections, waterways, port access and transit